

Peer Review of Grant Proposals

Adapted from the AZA Conservation Grants Fund Reviewer Evaluation Form

Overview

In this activity, you will act as **peer reviewers** for your classmates' Conservation Biology Student Grant Proposals. This exercise mirrors the review process used in the Association of Zoos & Aquariums (AZA) Conservation Grants Fund (CGF), and provides practice evaluating the quality, feasibility, clarity, and conservation significance of real conservation proposals.

This exercise will help you:

- Evaluate conservation proposals using professional criteria.
- Provide constructive, detailed written assessment.
- Make funding allocation decisions under a limited budget.
- Understand how reviewers prioritize competing conservation goals.

Instructions

1. You will be assigned **six (6)** proposals from your classmates.
2. First, complete detailed reviews for two assigned proposals.
 - a. For each proposal, complete the **Detailed Peer Reviewer Evaluation Form** included below.
3. Next, read the other four proposals to make an informed funding decision.
 - a. You do not need to complete full evaluations for these four proposals.
 - b. However, read them carefully enough to make an informed funding decision.
4. Submit your individual budget allocation after comparing all 6 proposals.

- a. You have a hypothetical conservation budget of **\$35,000** to distribute among the six proposals.
- b. Your task is to allocate these funds in a way that maximizes conservation impact, feasibility, and alignment with the One Plan Approach.
 - You may:
 - Fully fund proposals
 - Partially fund proposals
 - Decline to fund proposals
 - Assign an “Honorable Mention” (no funds)
 - The **two proposals that receive the highest total funding across all reviewers** will earn **extra credit** on the proposal assignment.

You will submit:

- A budget table showing your **funding allocation**
- A written **rationale** explaining your decisions

Detailed Peer Reviewer Evaluation Form 1

*Complete this section for **each** of your two assigned proposals.*

Proposal Title: _____

Reviewer Name: _____

Conservation Significance

- Does the project address a clear conservation or management need?
- Is the justification grounded in course concepts (biodiversity, threats, extinction risk, habitat loss, One Plan thinking)?

Comments:

Goals and Objectives

- Are goals and objectives specific, measurable, achievable within one year, and logically connected?
- Do they support meaningful long-term conservation outcomes?

Comments:

Methods, Monitoring, and Evaluation

- Are the proposed methods appropriate for the project's objectives?
- Is the study design, outreach plan, or implementation described clearly?
- Is there a realistic plan to evaluate success?

Comments:

Budget and Feasibility

- Are requested funds reasonable for the proposed scope of work?
- Are line items clearly justified?
- Is the project feasible given constraints?

Comments:

Overall Rating

- ☐ **5** Excellent proposal and project
- ☐ **4** Strong proposal and project
- ☐ **3** Average proposal and project
- ☐ **2** Some good ideas but not a strong proposal or priority project
- ☐ **1** Weak proposal and project

Provide a concise summary of the proposal's strengths and areas needing improvement.

Comments:

Detailed Peer Reviewer Evaluation Form 2

*Complete this section for **each** of your two assigned proposals.*

Proposal Title: _____

Reviewer Name: _____

Conservation Significance

- Does the project address a clear conservation or management need?
- Is the justification grounded in course concepts (biodiversity, threats, extinction risk, habitat loss, One Plan thinking)?

Comments:

Goals and Objectives

- Are goals and objectives specific, measurable, achievable within one year, and logically connected?
- Do they support meaningful long-term conservation outcomes?

Comments:

Methods, Monitoring, and Evaluation

- Are the proposed methods appropriate for the project's objectives?
- Is the study design, outreach plan, or implementation described clearly?
- Is there a realistic plan to evaluate success?

Comments:

Budget and Feasibility

- Are requested funds reasonable for the proposed scope of work?
- Are line items clearly justified?
- Is the project feasible given constraints?

Comments:

Overall Strengths and Weaknesses

Provide a concise summary of the proposal's strengths and areas needing improvement.

Comments:

Overall Rating

Using the scale below, rate the overall quality of this proposal.

- ☐ **5** Excellent proposal and project
- ☐ **4** Strong proposal and project
- ☐ **3** Average proposal and project
- ☐ **2** Some good ideas but not a strong proposal or priority project
- ☐ **1** Weak proposal and project

Your Individual Funding Allocation

After reviewing all six proposals, complete the table below.

Reviewer Name: _____

Total Budget Available: \$35,000

Proposal Title	Award Type (Full / Partial / None / Honorable Mention)	Amount Awarded
Proposal 1		_____
Proposal 2		_____
Proposal 3		_____
Proposal 4		_____
Proposal 5		_____
Proposal 6		_____
TOTAL		_____
SPENT		

Funding Rationale

Provide a short justification (1 paragraph) explaining:

- Why you allocated funds as you did
- How you balanced feasibility, clarity, and conservation significance
- Any tradeoffs or prioritization decisions

Rationale:
